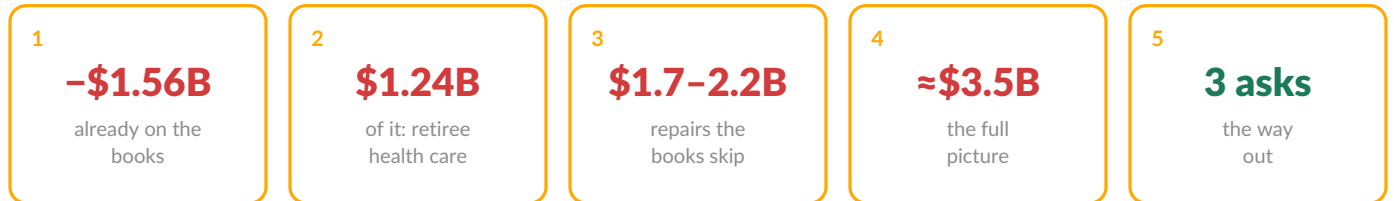


What does Buffalo really owe?

A one-page summary from the city's own audited reports (2006–2025) · buffalofinances.org



The picture, in plain English

Counting only the money it can spend, Buffalo owes about \$1.56 billion more than it holds — straight from the city's own audit. That gap is mostly health care promised to retirees that was never pre-funded (about \$1.24 billion), not borrowing: the city's bonded debt (about \$326 million) is the smallest piece.

And one real cost never reaches the books at all: repairing the roads, water mains, and buildings the city already owns. The audit records that about half their value is used up, but no report totals what fixing them would cost — an estimated \$1.7–2.2 billion. Together that's roughly \$3.5 billion, about \$30,000 per household.

THE ASK — ONE NUMBER, ONCE A YEAR

Publish a “cost of good repair” figure every year: what it would take to bring the city's roads, pipes, and buildings back to good condition. A rough first estimate can be built from figures already in the audit — federal agencies and New York City already publish theirs — and Buffalo's new data-driven paving program is exactly the right start.

It takes one Council member to request it.

Three questions worth asking your Council member

1. After closing this year's gap with a 19% tax increase and added state aid, what's the plan to build the 2027–28 budget on recurring revenue the city controls?
2. What is the plan to address the \$1.2 billion retiree-health obligation — on a real, published schedule?
3. Will you request a published “state of good repair” number this year?